



Image



Lobby introduces lactation rooms in schools to support teachers

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Sitna Omar-KNA

The Kenya Women Teachers Association (KEWOTA) is setting up lactation rooms in schools to help teachers effectively balance their professional duties and motherhood.

These facilities are intended to foster a more inclusive and supportive atmosphere for staff, resulting in enhanced job satisfaction and performance.

The association believes that by establishing lactation rooms, teachers can conduct classes without the stress of being away from their infants, as they can easily breastfeed during breaks.

Mercy Odhiambo, the coordinator of KEWOTA's Homa Bay branch, highlighted the advantages of having lactation facilities for the teachers and their babies adding that having a nearby facility saves them time, reducing the need to rush home to breastfeed.

“It helps improve the mental well-being of teachers, who may feel anxious about being away from their young children,” she noted.

She pointed out that separation from their children can cause mental distress for women during working hours, hampering their performance.

Odhiambo made these remarks during the official opening of a lactation facility at Ndhiwa Comprehensive School, a programme funded by KEWOTA.

“The association aims to implement the programme in as many schools as possible,” she said, and encouraged school heads in other areas to provide them with spaces to establish similar facilities.

KEWOTA's Marketing Manager, Daniel Oswago, stressed that these lactation rooms serve as safe spaces where teachers can comfortably bond with their babies without worry.

He added that the facility allows caregivers to bring children to school, so that teachers can breastfeed after classes or during their free time.

“This arrangement helps to enhance school performance as teachers will feel secure about their children's well-being, allowing them to focus fully on their work,” Oswago noted.

Ndhiwa Comprehensive School Deputy Headteacher, Nedy Dulo, mentioned that the usual maternity leave for teachers is four months, during which their babies are often still reliant on breast milk.

She said the lactation room would help reduce late arrivals and absenteeism among teachers who are inclined to care for their babies at home, resulting in such situations.

“We have allowed our female teachers to bring their babies to school to address these challenges,” she said.

The teachers expressed their gratitude for KEWOTA, noting that they often face difficulties leaving their young children at home while at work, making the facility a timely and valuable resource.

Pamela Otieno, a junior secondary school teacher, shared her experience of having to leave school to care for her 18-month-old son, who becomes very distressed when she is away.

She said that the facility is crucial for her and other teachers in similar situations.

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